

India doesn't need a moonshot fab before it has a portfolio of globally relevant designs, according to Madhu. The ecosystem must prove it can produce commercially viable silicon – repeatedly – before it dreams of leading-edge nodes.

When I ask about the toughest non-technology hurdle in building a chip company in India, he doesn't cite fabs or EDA tools. "Product marketing and capital are the biggest issues in India," says Madhusudan instantly.

Since Madhusudan has co-founded startups across indoor mapping, IPTV, health records, and financial terminals, experience has taught him pattern recognition. "It helps to have a pulse of the market, network incessantly, and listen well to customers."

And on capital? "Capital is easy to raise if you are clear in what you want to achieve and have a credible plan. Address real problems with credible solutions and investors will listen to you. Tech in search of a problem will never work." There's a certain old-school clarity in that statement – refreshing in an era of hype cycles and valuation theatre.

The InCore edge

So where does InCore fit in all of this? Madhusudan describes the company's competitive advantage succinctly: "Comprehensive solution for building RISC-V SoCs. IP + SoC generator + IP playstore make us unique."

The phrase "months to minutes" often accompanies their SoC generator pitch, which is a deterministic automation platform designed to compress prototyping cycles dramatically. The business model is "hybrid, where we combine our IP with tooling and a play store for third party IP. It is not a services model even though some services may be present. We do not stray from high gross margin business models," Madhusudan emphasizes. Not only is it clever, it's beautifully pragmatic.

And against incumbents with deeper pockets? Madhusudan says, "Nimble execution is not given enough credit!" You can almost hear the exclamation mark.

InCore's roadmap begins with embedded, high-volume processors before climbing toward more performance-intensive domains. "We are market driven. Our focus areas are where RISC-V is strong and also where volumes are huge."

PC and mobile? That's not just a silicon game. "PC and mobile depend

blunt: "Startups need a strong thesis both technical and marketing and one solid anchor prospect who has validated the thesis."

Industry and academia partnerships

Few people have inhabited both academic and commercial semiconductor worlds as deeply as Madhusudan. "It is like a jugalbandi!" he says, smiling at the metaphor. "Academia gave us space to explore concepts. Industry gives focus and direction."



on Microsoft, Google and Apple since they control the eco-system." What about HPC? "A long game and most RISC-V efforts have not had traction," sums up Madhusudan.

Therefore, InCore is doubling down on AI/ML and automotive verticals, with upcoming high-performance Dolomite cores and vector offerings. Madhusudan understands that markets decide roadmaps.

According to Madhusudan, he can't thank Peak XV enough, as they backed InCore early, at a time when semiconductor investing in India was hardly fashionable. "The founding team's breadth of talent, RISC-V market potential and the Shakti accomplishments convinced them." For startups looking to follow, he's

That interplay – curiosity disciplined by customer reality – may be India's secret weapon.

For young engineers contemplating India's semiconductor wave, Madhusudan's advice is both inviting and cautionary. "Jump in, it is the right time. But it is a long and hard journey, so think through what you are bringing to the table."

And then, almost mischievously: "Don't be scared of building commodity products." There's wisdom there. In semiconductors, "commodity" often means scale. And scale (in silicon terms) is power.

InCore is betting that the future of Indian semiconductors won't just be about catching up. It will be about building differently. **d**